# Pricing Without Scale: Revenue Management Adoption and Foregone Yield among Independent Hospitality Enterprises in Emerging Markets

**Abstract**

While revenue management (RM) is now a core skill of branded hotel chains, uptake of the practice among independent, mid-scale operators in emerging markets is still low. But many of these companies still use static, seasonally adjusted rate cards, which work best for them when they have perishable inventory and fixed capacity and when demand is volatile. This paper explores why this adoption gap has remained and what yield was lost as a result. Based on published industry reports and regional market frameworks, and combining micro-economic theories of capacity-constrained price discrimination with behavioural research on perceived price fairness, the paper presents a conceptual model of three interwoven barriers – a structural barrier related to the fixed costs and minimum efficient scale of RM systems; a technological barrier related to forecast error in situations with thin historical data; and a behavioural barrier related to the asymmetric fairness impact on firms lacking brand equity. The analysis indicates that in many cases, non-adoption is more of a rational reaction to such constraints than a managerial failure. It finds that scale-light, fairness-compatible RM architectures, such as rate fences and simple protection-level rules, are more suitable for independent operators than the imitation of chain-style dynamic pricing.

## 1. Introduction

It is where revenue management is least used that its economic logic is most compelling. A hotel room is a canonical perishable asset: an unsold room-night is not inventoried, there is a fixed supply in the short run and the marginal cost of an occupied room is low compared to the fixed cost of the hotel (Kimes, 1989). These conditions are exacerbated by the high seasonality in emerging Southeast Asian markets like Vietnam, the dynamic nature of international source markets, and the high proportion of small, mostly independent properties: Vietnam had approximately 38,000 accommodation establishments and 780,000 rooms nationwide, of which only around 500 were four- or five-star hotels (VietnamNet, 2022), while nearly 70 per cent of the hotel development pipeline is chain-branded (VietnamPlus, 2024). In this environment, the

standard theory suggests that differentiated, demand-sensitive pricing can be expected to significantly outperform uniform pricing.

Observed practice is very different from this prediction. International chains in the region have centralized RM teams, automated pricing systems and loyalty-based rate structures, and many independent mid-scale hotels still price their rooms by using fixed rate cards that are updated a few times a year, with some rooms being priced reactively on online travel agency (OTA) sites. This leads to a systematic difference in pricing sophistication across two classes of firms with broadly similar demand environments. Notably, published market reports seldom break down performance by brand affiliation, a gap in information that is itself indicative of the issue that this paper addresses.

This disjunction is only partly explainable with reference to existing scholarship. The RM literature is mostly in the context of mature Western markets, and the airline industry and large hotel chains, where the issue is not whether or not to adopt RM, but how to do it best. The behavioral literature on price fairness, on the other hand, has concentrated on consumers' responses to dynamic pricing, but not on the question of whether their responses vary between branded and independent sellers. As a result, there is no comprehensive understanding of the challenges that independent mid-scale operators face in emerging markets, both operational, technological and behavioural. This paper fills this void by asking the questions of why do these operators under-adopt dynamic yield management and what kind of RM is economically rational for them, given their constraints.

## 2. Literature Review

Kimes (1989) provided the theoretical background of revenue management in the hospitality industry and identified the conditions when it can be used and the for which it is a tool for capacity-constrained service firms. They are: Relatively fixed capacity, Perishable inventory, Segmentable demand, Advance sales, Fluctuating demand, and Low marginal sales costs, relative to high capacity change costs. The importance of this framework is that it is general; it considers structural conditions in the market and not the characteristics of the firm to be the factors of RM's value. By this measure, independent hotels in emerging markets meet the preconditions just as well as branded hotels, making the low uptake a puzzle.

The microeconomic explanation of these conditions is based on the theory of price discrimination. If there is a difference in willingness to pay between consumers and arbitrage between segments is limited, the firm can raise its revenues by selling the same or similar products at different prices (Pigou, 1920; Varian, 1989). This logic takes an intertemporal dimension in capacity-constrained environments. Littlewood (1972/2005) showed that a firm should keep a unit of capacity for a higher paying segment if the expected marginal revenue for the higher paying segment is greater than the sure revenue from a discounted sale. Gallego and van Ryzin (1994) later developed a model for optimal dynamic pricing of finite inventories when demand is stochastic. Both results suggest that the accuracy of the demand forecasting is a critical factor in the value of RM, especially for companies with limited historical data.

Consumers' perceptions of fairness, however, are a qualification on the economic case for RM. Kahneman, Knetsch and Thaler (1986) suggested the notion of dual entitlement: the firm is entitled to its reference profit and the consumer is entitled to a reference price. Rising prices that reflect the rising costs are acceptable; rising prices that reflect a change in demand are not acceptable, and will elicit punitive action. This account was completed by Thaler (1985), who demonstrated that consumers get transaction utility from the gap between the price paid and an internal reference price. A price that is thus seen as high compared to that reference thus represents a psychological loss in addition to the value of the good.

Kimes (1994) took these insights and applied them directly to the hospitality industry, and discovered that certain RM practices were potentially seen as unfair. Kimes and Wirtz (2003) continued this research by conducting an international study of rate fences and the results showed that pricing differences phrased in terms of discounts and linked to conditions that customers could control, such as advance purchase or time of consumption, were perceived as much more fair than demand-based surcharges. Theoretically, this is an important discovery. It suggests that the fairness clause does not rule out price discrimination altogether, but rather only regulates its form, to the detriment of opaque, fluctuating prices and in favour of transparent, fence-based ones. What has not been investigated is whether or not the size of this constraint varies systematically across firms. The literature has yet to ask the question the following

framework does: does brand equity and loyalty programs provide any buffer for chains from the full force of fairness penalties that are borne by independent operators?

## 3. Conceptual Framework and Analytical Methodology

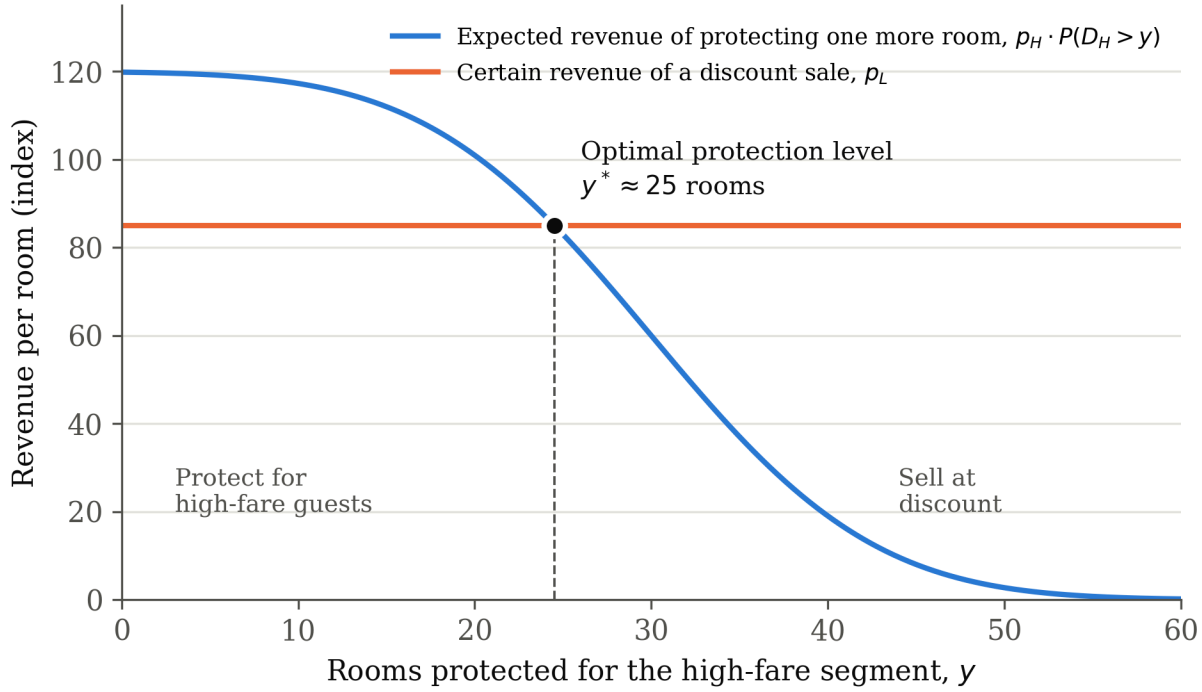
### 3.1 The Economic Model of Yield Loss

Typically, the effectiveness of a hotel's pricing policy is encapsulated in revenue per available room (RevPAR), which is the total room revenue divided by the number of available room-nights for a period. RevPAR can be broken down into the average daily rate (ADR) times the number of rooms sold, which is the same as the room revenue. This decomposition is analytically useful as it renders the trade-off in the heart of revenue management explicit. A pricing policy can increase ADR at the expense of occupancy or increase occupancy at the expense of ADR, and it is the policy that maximizes the product, not either component alone, that is the best option (Kimes, 1989). When demand is not uniform over time and across customer groups, a firm that cares only about occupancy, as a static pricing regime implicitly does, will systematically fail to maximize RevPAR.

Littlewood's (1972/2005) two-class rule is a representation of the capacity-allocation problem associated with this trade-off. Suppose a hotel with a fixed capacity C has two segments: one that is price sensitive and books early at a discounted price p_L, and the other that is less price sensitive and books later at a higher price p_H. Low fare demand is likely to come first, and the firm must determine how many rooms to reserve for the unknown subsequent high fare demand, D_H. Littlewood's rule says that until the expected revenue from providing the additional room (p_H times the probability that the high-fare demand is greater than the current level of protection) is greater than the certain discounted revenue from the current protection (p_L), the firm should provide the additional room. The optimal protection level y* is thus the level where the probability of $D_H > y^*$ is equal to the fare ratio $p_L / p_H$. Two implications follow. First, the optimal allocation does not only depend on the mean of the high fare demand, but also on its distribution. Second, if the demand for high fare is close to normal with mean $\mu$ and standard deviation $\sigma$, the level of protection can be expressed as $\mu + \sigma z$, where z is the standard normal quantile associated with $1 - p_L / p_H$. The result is that mistakes in estimating $\mu$ and $\sigma$ are directly proportional to mistakes in allocating capacity. This gives a formal relationship between

data availability and the value of RM: the thinner or noisier the booking history of a firm, the less accurately they will be able to set protection levels, and the lower the expected return from capacity controls will be.

Figure 1. Littlewood's two-class rule




Illustrative parameters: $p_H = 120$, $p_L = 85$, high-fare demand ~ Normal(30, 10). Not empirical estimates.

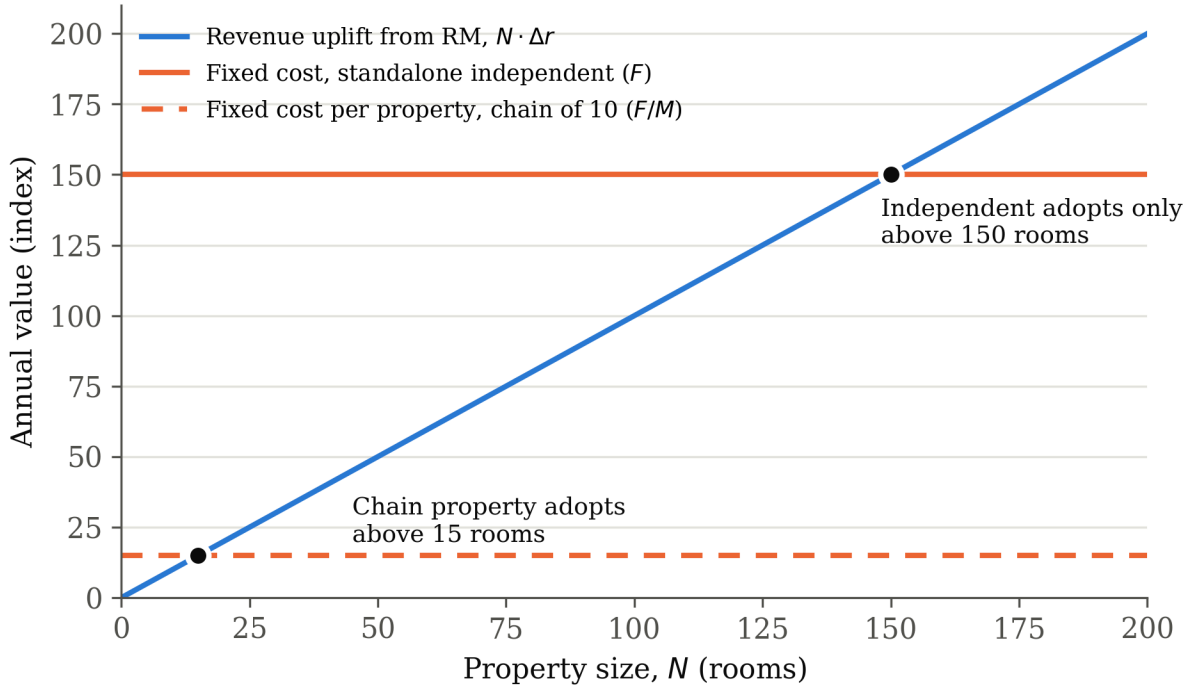
Figure 1 illustrates the rule: the optimal protection level lies where the expected marginal revenue of a protected room equals the discount fare.

The static rate card can be interpreted as a degenerate pricing policy, in which a single price (or a few seasonal prices) is charged, no matter what the realized demand is. This is because of the price elasticity of demand. During low demand periods when demand is relatively elastic, a price equal to the seasonal average is above the equilibrium and results in some rooms being unsold that could have been sold at a lower price that is still greater than the marginal cost. During high demand times when demand is relatively inelastic, and capacity is binding, the same price is too low. Rooms are then allocated to the next group of guests willing to pay more on a first come first served basis, with higher value later demand being displaced. Foregone yield can then be

seen as the total over time of the difference between revenue that could be achieved with an elasticity responsive policy and the revenue that is achieved with the static rate card. In theory, this amount is always non-negative and increases as demand becomes more volatile and the willingness to pay becomes more spread out between segments.

But whether a firm can profit from this forgone yield depends on whether adoption is economically rational. Define F as the fixed cost of an RM capability (e.g. software, specialist labour, data infrastructure etc.) and Δr as the expected per-room revenue uplift. A single property with N rooms adopts RM only if N·Δr is greater than F. A chain with M properties can spread F across its portfolio and combine the demand data across properties, which lowers the cost of F and the forecast error per property. As a result, the adoption threshold decreases as the size of the portfolio increases, and many stand-alone operators rationally decide not to invest below this threshold.

Figure 2. The RM adoption threshold and minimum efficient scale




Illustrative parameters: $F$ = 150, $\Delta r$ = 1 per room, $M$ = 10 properties. Not empirical estimates.

As Figure 2 shows, spreading the fixed cost across a portfolio lowers the scale at which adoption becomes rational by a factor of M.

### 3.2 Behavioral Rate Fences and Consumer Trust

The above model assumes that revenue depends only on price and allocation. Behavioral evidence suggests that the complete specification should also feature a goodwill cost due to perceived unfairness (Kahneman et al., 1986). This cost can be thought of as a function of the difference between the posted price and the consumer's reference price, and a function of the consumer's trust in the seller. According to this specification, a price increase has different costs for different firms. Branded chains have two ways of reducing the impact of the penalty – brand equity, which provides a sense of consistent quality and good intentions, and loyalty programs, which redefine price differences as differential access to members rather than exploitation. An independent operator, having neither, is liable for the full amount of the fairness penalty, as each price change is compared to an unmediated reference price.

Rate fences can be used to implement price discrimination without incurring this penalty. Non-physical fences, like advance-purchase requirements, non-refundable terms and minimum length-of-stay conditions, distinguish rates based on the conditions of the transaction, not the timing of demand. This attribution matters. If a lower rate is clearly dependent upon the guest agreeing to restrictions, the price difference is considered to be a difference in the product and the reference price for the flexible rate is not affected. Arbitrary surge pricing, on the other hand, does not provide the same attribution: it's the same product being sold at a higher price, just because the demand has increased – which is exactly what dual entitlement calls unfair. As predicted by Kimes and Wirtz (2003), fences that are presented as discounts from a fixed reference rate and are linked to controllable conditions are likely to maintain trust while allowing for segmentation. Fences are thus the part of the RM toolkit that has the lowest ratio of revenue benefits to fairness costs for independent operators.

### 3.3 Secondary Data Synthesis Approach

Foregone yield is not econometrically estimated in this paper, due to the proprietary nature of the property-level transaction data. Rather, it combines market-level indicators from published sources to assess the circumstances in which foregone yield is likely to be substantial. The amplitude of demand variation is described based on the market level occupancy, ADR, RevPAR

indicators published by Savills Hotels and the national tourism statistics by General Statistics Office of Vietnam. For instance, in Hanoi, the occupancy rate in the second quarter of 2023 was 62 per cent, compared to 73 per cent in 2019, while the average room rate increased by 26 per cent year on year (Vietnam.vn, 2023). It is the pattern of divergence of this kind between the price and quantity components of RevPAR that the framework tries to interpret. National accommodation statistics are used to characterize market structure.

These indicators are then used in conjunction with the model in Section 3.1 to develop illustrative scenarios. In each scenario, a representative independent hotel charges a fixed seasonal rate, and a benchmark policy sets the rate based on demand, using assumed elasticities. The difference in scenario RevPAR is an illustrative, bounded estimate of foregone yield, not a point estimate. Three drawbacks of this approach are recognized. Aggregate market data combine branded and independent properties, published data vary in sampling frames and definitions, and elasticity parameters are assumed. In line with the conceptual approach of the study, the results are interpreted as analytical statements that can be tested in future property-level studies.

## 4. Industry Analysis, Empirical Findings, and Barriers to Adoption

### 4.1 Foregone Yield in Emerging Markets

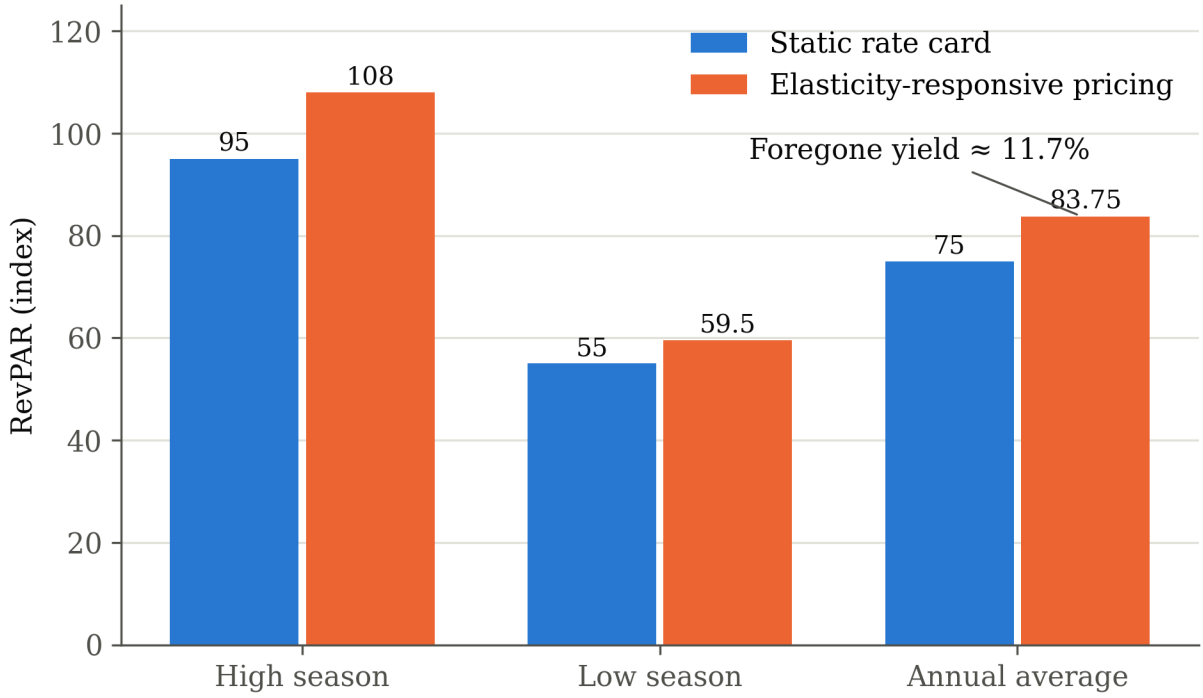
After the international borders were reopened in 2022, international arrivals bounced back in 2024, reaching 17.6 million, which is quite near the highest level in 2019 before the pandemic (Vietnam News, 2025) and further increased to about 21 million in 2025 (Vietnam Investment Review, 2026). Hotel performance bounced back in a mixed fashion. Despite the average rate drop of 3 per cent, RevPAR increased 15 per cent in the first seven months of 2024, driven by occupancy at coastal destinations (VietnamPlus, 2024). RevPAR, in particular, had increased 17 per cent year on year across the country, and in Hanoi and Ho Chi Minh City, the growth was largely due to higher room rates (VietnamNet, 2025).

If published data allows for a differentiation between branded and independent performance, the indicator is the relative behavior of ADR and occupancy. Yield optimizers should be more responsive to demand for ADR, and their occupancy should be comparatively stable. The

opposite trend is likely to be seen for firms with static rate cards, where they are expected to adjust by quantity, not price. As of yet, there are no public data available for Vietnam that can distinguish branded from independent performance, so this prediction can not be tested directly.

A stylized example based on the framework of Section 3.1 can be used to illustrate the size of foregone yield. The parameters are illustrative and indexed, and are not empirical estimates. Let's take the case of a typical hotel that runs in two seasons of equal length. With a static rate card with an index of 100, the property has 95 per cent occupancy in the high season and 55 per cent occupancy in the low season, which equals RevPARs of 95 and 55, and an average of 75. With the elasticity-responsive policy, the property's high season rate is set at 120, which only slightly lowers the high season occupancy to 90 per cent, since demand for high season is relatively inelastic. It cuts its low season rate to 85, thereby increasing occupancy to 70 per cent as the demand for this rate is relatively elastic. Seasonal RevPARs are now 108 and 59.5, with average RevPAR now at 83.75. This foregone yield of the static policy is around 11.7 per cent of its RevPAR.

Figure 3. RevPAR under static and elasticity-responsive pricing




Illustrative, indexed parameters (static rate = 100); not empirical estimates.

Figure 3 summarizes the scenario, showing that the static policy underperforms in both seasons through opposite mechanisms.

There are two aspects of this illustration that should be highlighted. First, the gain occurs in both seasons, but is generated by different mechanisms. The static policy creates a dead weight loss in the off-season because rooms are not being used but people would be willing to pay more than the marginal cost for those rooms, so mutually beneficial trades are not taking place. During the high season, the loss is allocative, not deadweight: rooms are being sold, but they are being sold to lower valued demand, that is, to guests who are willing to pay less for a room than other guests, thus displacing the later high valued demand. Second, the illustration assumes too much net gain for the independent operator, since it ignores the fixed cost of RM, the extent to which the forecast could differ from the optimum, and the fairness penalty, discussed below. The correct reading is that foregone yield in static pricing is likely to be economically significant, but that the share that an independent operator can capture is limited by the barriers examined in the following.

### 4.2 Structural and Human Barriers to Adoption

#### Barrier 1: Information Asymmetry and Technological Infrastructure

The first obstacle is information. Yield optimization requires accurate demand forecasting and the knowledge of the competitors' price, which is expensive. Branded chains enjoy the advantage of central reservation systems that pool booking data across properties, integration with property management and pricing systems and subscriptions to competitive benchmarking services. Independent operators often miss one or more of these and many rely on online travel agencies (OTAs) for a significant portion of their bookings. This dependence gives rise to a structural asymmetric-information problem: the intermediary knows what the search and booking activity is across the market, but the hotel knows what it has sold only. As a result, the hotel's demand forecasts are based on less data than the chain's competitors and the distribution partners. As demonstrated in Section 3.1, the higher the variance of the forecast, the lower the expected return on capacity controls, which may make an independent rationally unwilling to invest in RM tools whose output is not reliably calibrated.

**Barrier 2: Fear of Guest Backlash and Perceived Unfairness**

Behavioral is the second barrier. In many emerging markets, independent mid-scale hotels rely on repeat domestic customers, corporate business and relational distribution models where the price is an implicit contract. In the case of a dual entitlement, such visitors have clearly defined reference prices, and a demand-driven rise would probably be seen as opportunism (Kahneman et al., 1986). The effects are amplified because of the visibility of online reviews, where perceived unfairness is passed on to future guests. Without the brand equity and loyalty architecture that buffer chains, independents rationally believe that they will face a bigger fairness penalty. The analysis indicates that this limitation is often misdiagnosed, however. Operators tend to assume that any price change is risky, but the evidence suggests that the penalty is more related to unfenced price increases based on demand than to fenced price differentiation based on conditions (Kimes & Wirtz, 2003). The behavioral barrier thus does not prevent an independent from adopting the RM, but rather limits the type of RM that can be adopted.

**Barrier 3: Owner-Operator Risk Aversion and Managerial Incentives**

The third barrier is governance. With chain operations, pricing is delegated to professional managers whose incentive contracts are usually linked to RevPAR, and whose employers own a diversified portfolio which can withstand property-level variations. In owner-operated independents, in contrast, the decision-maker is the one who faces all of the costs of a wrong price choice, and outcomes are not symmetrically salient. A room that is empty after a rate change is a loss that the owner can see, but revenue that is lost by not charging a high enough rate is an opportunity cost that cannot be seen. Loss aversion says that such owners will give more weight to the former (Tversky & Kahneman, 1991), while status quo bias suggests a preference for familiar rate cards over alternatives that have not been tested (Samuelson & Zeckhauser, 1988). This leads to a systematic bias towards chasing occupancy as opposed to RevPAR. There is no easy solution to delegation, because the agency costs of delegation (Jensen & Meckling, 1976) are larger in proportion to the size of the property for one than for a chain.

The three barriers are not independent, but act as mutually reinforcing barriers. Thin data lead to more forecast error, which in turn leads to more visible pricing errors, which leads to an increase in the fairness penalty and an increase in the owner's loss aversion, which finally leads to a decrease in the expected return of the fixed investment that RM needs. The continued existence of static pricing among independent operators is therefore best thought of as an equilibrium outcome of interacting constraints, and not as lack of management.

## 5. Strategic Discussion, Limitations, and Conclusion

### 5.1 Strategic and Policy Implications

The foregoing analysis suggests that independent operators should not emulate the chain's way of dynamic pricing, but should rather adopt a sequenced, scale-light revenue management architecture. The first is a fenced rate structure. By providing advance-purchase, non-refundable, and length-of-stay rates as discounts from a stable reference rate, an operator can differentiate demand based on willingness to pay while maintaining a reference rate for fairness (Kimes & Wirtz, 2003). Fences do not need to be complicated, or to be revised continuously based on the prices, but they do allow to harvest a reasonable part of the available yield at a minimum fixed cost.

The second factor is the use of simple protection-level rules on predictable peak dates. Littlewood's rule is easy to compute: it only involves the fare ratio and an approximate assessment of the probability of high-fare demand occurring (Talluri & van Ryzin, 2004). Selectively applied, these rules respond to the allocative inefficiency of underpricing in the high season while avoiding the operator being constantly subject to forecast error. The third is the intentional allocation of channels. OTA inventory should no longer be a passive default, but rather a channel that can be viewed as a separate segment with different cost of distribution, and also be aware that OTA listings can create visibility that can lead to direct bookings (Anderson, 2009).

The structural barrier is not however one that can be addressed at the individual firm level, as the fixed cost of RM capability is not dependent on the size of the property. This reflects the importance of institutional structures that enable independents to share fixed costs, such as

cluster based RM services, outsourcing revenue management, and soft-branding with distribution and data infrastructure, but not full chain ownership. Public and associative actors are also involved. Information asymmetry could be mitigated by timely and disaggregated market benchmarks published by the tourism authorities and/or hotel associations; the digital transformation programs for SMEs could be subsidized to facilitate the implementation of integrated property-management and pricing systems. Finally, independent owners can solve the governance issue internally by changing the evaluation of their performance from occupancy to RevPAR, making the opportunity cost of underpricing as apparent as the cost of vacancy.

### 5.2 Limitations and Future Research

These conclusions are subject to several limitations. First, the empirical basis of the paper is based on the use of aggregate secondary data that combine branded and independent properties, with varying sampling frames and definitions of properties across data sources. The analysis can therefore only determine when foregone yield is likely to be material, not its size for any set of firms. Second, the illustrative scenario uses assumed elasticities, which vary from market to market, segment to segment and season to season. Third, the proposed fairness asymmetry between branded and independent sellers is not directly observed. Future directions for research are indicated by each limitation. Panel data at the property level could be used to test the hypothesis that the timing of RM adoption is related to size and membership of the portfolio, as suggested by the adoption-threshold model. Primary empirical research and discrete choice experiments with travelers in emerging markets could be used to gauge the relative acceptability of fenced and unfenced pricing, as well as to assess whether perceived unfairness is moderated by brand loyalty. A comparative study of the barriers encountered in other markets in Southeast Asia would be able to determine the extent to which the barriers found in this study are general or specific to the context.

### 5.3 Conclusion

This paper has explored the reasons behind the under-adoption of RM by independent hospitality businesses in emerging markets, where they are most likely to benefit from it. It has suggested that the foregone yield is not the result of any ignorance on the part of the manager but a rational equilibrium brought about by three interdependent limitations. A structural constraint is due to

the fixed cost and minimum efficient scale of RM capability; a behavioral constraint is due to the fairness penalty that is more costly for firms without brand equity; and an organizational constraint is due to the risk aversion and incentive structure of owner-operated governance. The bottom line is that dynamic pricing in independent accommodation isn't just a technology issue that can be addressed with software. It's also a behavioral issue of maintaining consumer trust and a governance issue of putting incentives of decision makers in line with yield optimization. Thus, the best strategy for independent operators is not simply to follow the lead of the chains in their pricing, but to use methods of revenue management that are geared to the limitations that separate them.

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